candidates who were willing to contest on their symbol. Then they got only four seats. But in the 1991 Lok Sabha polls, the BJP candidates came first or a close second in over a hundred assembly constituencies and raised their percentage of the vote from 2.5 percent to 30 percent. Now there is a queue for BJP tickets, and if they are not careful, the Congress will once again sit in the opposition in Karnataka.'[38]

For many Lingayat voters, Patil's removal was a sign of the 'eclipse of Lingayat power in Karnataka. Within the Congress Party, there was no other Lingayat leader who could be projected as a substitute.'[39] It was a critical moment because, although Yediyurappa was Lingayat too, 'this community was never with BJP till the late-1980s', says V. Anand, who managed Yediyurappa's social media and communications campaign in 2018. We were meeting over lunch in Bengaluru in February 2020. Anand emphasised the critical role of the Lingayat vote in the BJP's growth. By now, it was estimated to be between 17 and 19 per cent of the state's population.[40] 'That incident with Patil changed things forever and helped BJP in 1990,' he said. 'It was seen as the humiliation of the Lingayat community, and Congress never recovered from that. This 17–19 per cent of the population, which was committed to the Congress, was now alienated and more. Thanks to Yediyurappa, BJP could catch this group. Since then, they have never left the BJP or Yediyurappa, and that was the price Congress paid.'[41]

It is important to stress that the Lingayat vote did not shift immediately, nor can it be regarded as a monolith. However, the Patil incident began a process whereby, through the 1990s, a major chunk of Lingayat voters, who had initially shifted to the Janata Party in the 1980s, gradually began moving to the BJP. Initially, this vote bank was split between the Janata Party, the Janata Dal, the Janata Dal (S) and the BJP. Over time, it came to form a solid caste-based block that served as the fulcrum of the BJP's growth in north and central Karnataka. The Lingayat vote was particularly potent for the party because it was concentrated in about seventy seats, with influence in another thirty. In comparison, by 2018, former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda's JD(S)'s primary vote base had narrowed down geographically to the Vokkaliga-dominant areas of